The Reflective Interaction Observation Scale (RIOS): Understanding the Dyadic Process of Reflective Supervision

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Overview and Model Development

The **Reflective Interaction Observation Scale (RIOS)©** describes and operationalizes the nature of the interactions between a supervisor and supervisee(s) during reflective supervision.

7 Year, Collaborative Development Effort

- University of Minnesota Researchers
- Endorsed Infant Mental Health Clinicians and Reflective Supervision Providers in the Minnesota Association for Infant and Early Childhood Mental Health,
- Alliance for the Advance of Infant Mental Health

Development Methods

Professionals with years of reflective supervision experience, clinical infant mental health practice, and research expertise:

- coded videotapes of reflective supervision sessions to identify the components of the interactions between the supervisors and supervisees
- conducted a thematic analysis of the data to begin to hone in on essential elements of the reflective supervision process
- established face and construct validity of these elements through an extensive literature review and via a survey sent to a broad national group of experts through a modified Delphi process (Linstone & Turoff, 1975)
- held monthly calls to thoroughly vet the Essential Elements, Collaborative Tasks and Indicators
- met face-to-face to compose detailed descriptions of the tool and review videotaped sessions to identify video exemplars for reliability training

Using the Model: Coding Process

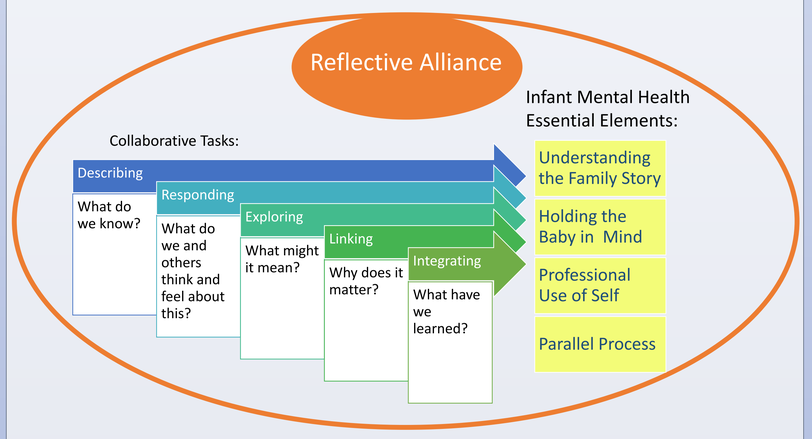
Digitally recorded reflective sessions are coded in 15 minute sections. A 1-5 code is given to each of the five Essential Elements, corresponding to the "highest" Collaborative Task undertaken during the 15 minute segment.

Publication

Watson, C., Harrison, M., Hennes, J. & Harris, M. (2016). Revealing "the space between": Creating an observation scale to understand infant mental health reflective supervision. ZERO TO THREE, 37(2) pp. 12-19.

Model

Reflective Interaction Observation Scale (RIOS)©



The RIOS is organized around five core Essential Elements that constitute the content of the discussion conducted between the supervisor and supervisee during a reflective session:

FIVE CORE ESSENTIAL ELEMENTS

Understanding the Family Story

Holding the Baby in Mind

Professional Use of Self

Parallel Process

Reflective Alliance

Interactions between supervisor and supervisee(s) are identified as "Collaborative Tasks":

FIVE COLLABORATIVE TASKS

Describing

Responding

Exploring

Linking

Integrating

There are observable "Indicators" for each of the Collaborative Tasks associated with the Essential Elements. The *Indicators* are defined as examples of "topics of conversation, observable behaviors and ways of interacting."

Example: Holding the Baby in Mind

1. Describing: "What do we know about the baby?

The supervisor and supervisee focus on the facts of the baby's experience including what was seen and heard.

- **Indicators of the Collaborative Task—Describing:**
  - Discussing factual information and what has transpired
  - Discussing observations of the baby, highlighting baby's interaction with others
  - Clarifying and organizing what is known about the baby's experience

2. Responding: "What do we and others think and feel about this?" The supervisor and supervisee consider what they and others think and feel about the baby and the caregiving environment.

- **Indicator of the Collaborative Task—Responding:**
  - Expressing thoughts and feelings related to the baby

3. Exploring: "What might this mean? The distinguishing characteristic is a deep exploration of the lived experience of the baby, with a deliberate and thoughtful discussion of what is known about the baby or what the baby's experience with the caregiver(s) might mean.

- **Indicators of the Collaborative Task—Exploring**
  - Seeking insight into the baby's experience
  - Attempting to acknowledge difficult issues and concerns for the baby
  - Searching for meaning in impressions, themes, and patterns in the baby's experience

4. Linking: "Why does it matter?" The reflective partners seek connection between the baby's experience and fundamental theoretical principles that might clarify and organize understanding of the work.

- **Indicator of the Collaborative Task—Linking:**
  - Identifying connections between this baby's experience and relevant theory and principles

5. Integrating: "What have we learned?" The supervisor and supervisee use their understanding about what they have learned together to form a summary of the baby's experience and the baby's impact on developing relationships.

- **Indicators of the Collaborative Task—Integrating:**
  - Developing a summary of what has been discovered about this baby
  - Anticipating the impact of this baby's development on relationships
  - Exploring the implications of the work going forward given the baby's current and anticipated developmental needs

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